

Communication

How you talk determines how you work together. Players learn the difference between reacting and truly communicating — and how to give feedback without damaging relationships.

⌚ 40 minutes

Group + individual

3 exercises

Evidence-based

Multiple studies on communication training in sport teams show improvements in cohesion — see **Tod et al. (2011)**.

Holt et al. (2020) — teams that trained 8 weeks of nonviolent communication (NVC) showed significantly higher social cohesion and fewer conflicts. *Psychology of Sport & Exercise*.

Turnnidge & Côté (2018) — positive, information-rich communication correlates with higher enjoyment, motivation and perseverance in young athletes.

1

The I-Message

The model: 'I see... I feel... I need... I ask you to...'

'I see...' (fact) → 'I feel...' (emotion) → 'I need...' (need) → 'I ask you to...' (request).

Players write out a real situation from their sporting life using this model — no blame, but clarity.

Use it yourself: stop with 'You did that wrong.' Begin with 'I see you leaving the position. I need you to wait.' Players will adopt it.

2

The Conversation I Postpone

WITH WHOM & WHY

Write down who the conversation is with and why you postpone it. Honesty with yourself is the first step.

OPENING LINE & DATE

Write the opening line (use the I-Message) and plan a concrete date + place. Accountability makes it real.

Follow up: ask the following week whether the conversation happened. Otherwise it stays just an intention.

3

Feedback Round Trio

Role A gives feedback on something concrete, Role B receives, Role C observes only tone and word choice — not content.

After 3 minutes the observer gives 30 seconds back: 'You said... That sounded like...' No judgement. Then switch roles.

Scan the mood: if there's tension, start with strengths before moving to growth points.



"Communication is the most important skill any leader can possess. I talked to my players like human beings, not pieces on a chess board, and that changed everything."

Doc Rivers — NBA Head Coach

Tips for this session



Tip 1 — Your own language

Introduce the I-Message in your own coaching language. Players adopt the model when they hear it from you.



Tip 2 — Make it concrete

Ask players to schedule a date for their difficult conversation and follow up the next week.



Tip 3 — Be patient

U14-U16 are still developing empathy. The goal is awareness, not perfection. One conscious I-message a month is already a success.



Careful: tension

The feedback round can get intense with tension. Scan the group dynamic and start with positive feedback.

8' Practise individually with worksheet

7' Debrief and reflection

2' Plan difficult-conversation intention

**Truly
spoken.**

⚡ TEAM RITUAL · THE CIRCLE

Stand together in a circle. Each player says the name of one teammate + one word why they appreciated him/her today. Start yourself as moderator. Name + word — nothing more.

NEXT MONTH → TEAM FIRST

Ask players to deliberately help one teammate this month without it being noticed. Next month: Team First.